

might have thought, before asking Sooryavanshi to stay back for a more intense test. Side-arm specialists, capable of delivering at speeds touching 157-158 kmph, were instructed to test him with a new ball.

Bharucha thought he was in command.

"I was clear in my head that this kid won't have it easy now."

Sooryavanshi began cautiously, leaving the initial deliveries with almost ascetic discipline. Then came the statement.

"As the sidearmer continued to hit the deck hard, Sooryavanshi smashed two straight sixes over the sightscreen. Back to back. I asked for the speed, and was surprised to know that they were 155 kph and 157 kmph respectively. That was unbelievable!"

Bharucha was seeing flashes of a young Tendulkar. That was when he became "100 per cent sure" that RR had to sign him.

As soon as the trials ended for the day, he texted Jake Lush McCrum, then CEO of the franchise: "All plans gone for a toss, boss. Generational talent on display at trials."

A curious McCrum wanted to know more. Bharucha simply asked him to set aside Rs. 10 crore for Sooryavanshi at the auction before adding that the lad was "probably better than [Yashasvi] Jaiswal when he first came in."

"This guy is only 13. Probably the best 13-year-old in the history of our sport after SRT," Bharucha wrote.

Rahul Dravid, then head coach, was the next to be informed.

Royals eventually secured Sooryavanshi for just Rs. 1.1 crore. The real challenge, however, was ensuring he was not swayed by money and fame.

Dravid believed the focus should not merely be on development, but also on protection, creating an environment where the youngster could grow without being overwhelmed by external pressures.

"Rahul was very clear about it. He brought all these guys into the room and basically laid out how we are supposed to let this kid be a kid,"



Young Turk: Rajasthan Royals opener Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, 14 at the time, made history as the youngest player to hit a century in men's T20s when he smacked 101 from 38 balls in 2025 against Gujarat Titans. THE HINDU

Bharucha says.

The philosophy has endured.

Under Kumar Sangakkara, the emphasis remains on preserving Sooryavanshi's natural approach while ensuring he is not burdened by expectations. During pre-season, he spends most of his time at the Talegaon facility under the watchful eye of manager Romi Bhinder, whom he considers a guardian.

Over the years, the Royals have transformed several young cricketers into stars, from Ravindra Jadeja to Sanju Samson and now Jaiswal. Bharucha believes the environment has been key.

"When Dhruv Jurel came in, he saw Jaiswal spending hours at the nets and making it to the national

team. So Dhruv followed. Then Riyan Parag. And now Vaibhav sees them doing the same," Bharucha says, adding: "This is a very contagious habit, perhaps the best thing to happen in Indian cricket!"

Perhaps it is. But it is imperative that Sooryavanshi, given his age, is handled carefully, especially considering how talents like Prithvi Shaw have faded despite promising starts.

Sangakkara, however, wants him to stay in the present.

"For Vaibhav, the most important thing is to enjoy playing cricket. And he must never lose that freedom," he says.

"Failure is a very strong word. My message to Vaibhav is that he's got